So did scores of other district-level journalists, academics and social notables. Rajesh Sharma helped immensely with the research.

I only really had the courage to begin this book after Robin Jeffrey endorsed the idea of it over a long dinner in Jaipur. It grew at every stage, and after countless conversations with him. Robin read and corrected every draft of the manuscript ‘as if he had been paid’ to do it. Mahesh Rangarajan, whose nuanced understanding of politics I have always admired, examined the manuscript with a historian’s critical lens and a political analyst’s sharp eye for detail in record time. He never took more than twenty-four hours to read any chapter and his long and meticulously handwritten annotations and comments on each page filled the gaps, driving me in new directions. The thoughtful Assa Doron improved the draft with an anthropologist’s scepticism and kept providing reality checks, including on my health and heart rate. Shubhashis Gangopadhyay put the manuscript through an economist’s microscope and told me to ‘stop beating around the bush and say it as it is’. T.M. Veeraraghav read every word, was a constant tutor in the intricacies of politics in South India and never complained, though I drove him up the wall till the end, urging him to make phone calls to sources for checking obscure details from ages ago. Soma Wadhwa’s angry, shouting pushback on the first draft of the chapter on women and a passionate three-hour-long phone argument with her made me rewrite it in significant measure.

Support and advice from Rohit Saran, peerless editor and storyteller of numbers, was particularly precious. It was Rohit who first introduced me to the world of data journalism and visualisation. This book, in many ways, is an unintended by-product of the baby lessons I initially learnt from him in two different newsrooms. So, getting a thumbs up from him on the draft felt truly special, though, as always, he told me to improve the graphics and wanted to know every little detail of how they would finally appear (‘delete that map there and move this one here, it breaks the flow,’ he said as he handed back the manuscript).

Vikas Singh, brilliant wordsmith and editor, who never misses a thing, read each chapter at super-speed, as he always does. So did the formidable Sharvani Pandit, who never minces her words. Only